

way: “The Great Recession and how shoppers responded to it have fundamentally changed the future of retail.”

Is all this another way to say marketers should be very afraid of the new breed of shopper, the frugal consumer? Not at all. Perhaps just a bit wary. They may need to tweak their marketing tactics a bit. Unless, of course, the lagging economy also increases the number of extreme “cherry pickers,” which is not necessarily the same category as the “extreme couponer.” The extreme “cherry picker” is the grocery store shopper who buys only sale items and nothing else. Cherry-pickers obtain 76 percent of potential savings at stores, stocking up on the negative profit items. Selling loss leaders is a necessary evil for grocery retailers since those sales help retain the existing customer base. The loss leaders at stores draw in the customers with the assumption that once inside the store, the customer will buy other items. Extreme cherry pickers, however, are more likely to come into the store only to load a cart with the sale merchandise, and then drive across town to do the same with a different sale item in another store.

On second thought, that does sound a lot like the extreme couponer.

In my own case, that is exactly what has happened when local stores experimented with double or even triple couponing. As soon as I got wind of an upcoming double coupon opportunity, I sorted through my coupon box for the highest-value coupons that might net a free product when doubled, whether I needed the item or not. If I was familiar with the store and the prices, I had a pretty good idea what coupons might result in free products. \$1 off toothpaste? Check. \$1 off deodorant? Maybe. \$1 off Tylenol? Might not be free, but I go through a lot, and it could still be a